GLOBAL CONFLUENCE REVIEW

BOOK OF ABSTRACTS

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Impact Investments in India: Gender and Regional Differences
Full author name	Samarth Misra
School name	RN Podar
School address	--
Email id	thesamarth09@gmail.com
Abstract	Impact investing is a form of investing that focuses not only on financial returns but also on creating positive social and environmental impact. This paper studies gender and regional differences in impact investing in India. The study specifically examines whether the impact of impact investments differs between male and female beneficiaries. In addition, it explores whether the outcomes of impact investments originating in India differ from those made by investors from the rest of the world. Using the secondary data of 180 investors, from India and the rest of the world, an independent t-test was conducted to analyze four key impact indicators: number of states impacted, number of lives impacted, days of livelihood generated, and credit histories created. The results show significant gender differences at the global level, with male investors having a higher average impact across all four indicators. In India, the gender gap is even stronger and statistically significant, depicting that investments by males have a higher social and environmental impact than those by females. However, in the countries apart from India, the differences between men and women are not statistically significant, demonstrating that males and females have an equal impact through their social investments. The findings suggest that structural, cultural, and financial factors influence these differences. Hence, this study highlights the importance of creating gender-inclusive policies to encourage greater female participation in impact investing.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Quality Assessment of Bitcoin Prices Using Seasonal Decomposition and Time Series Trend Analysis
Full author name	Akanksha Aravinda Gowda
School name	The International School Bangalore NAFL Valley
School address	Circle, Sarjapur Road, near Dommasandra, Whitefield, Thigala Chowdadenahalli, Karnataka 562125
Email id	akankshaga24@gmail.com
Abstract	Abstract Background/Objective Cryptocurrency have emerged as a crucial component of the worldwide financial system, with Bitcoin being one of the most prominently traded cryptocurrency. This study examines the long-term price trend of Bitcoin from August of 2010 to January of 2026 using Seasonal Decomposition Analysis and Time Series Analysis. Methods Published databases were used to fetch Bitcoin prices throughout the time period. The trend, R^2 value and the seasonal decompositions were conducted to examine the frequency of any correlated seasonal trends that Bitcoin may have with the price. Results The analysis showed that Bitcoin has had a definite upward trend during the period. The model of exponential trend accounted for 87.5% of the price variation (R^2 = 0.875), and the CAGR of 133.6% showed significant long-term increases. The seasonality analysis revealed very low seasonality (seasonal strength = 0.055) indicating that the price variability was mostly due to market fluctuations and market growth and there was little seasonal variation. Conclusions The price action of Bitcoin from 2010 to 2026 did not follow a distinct seasonal pattern, instead, the long-term trend was far more influential. The cryptocurrency market showed some volatility, but it is generally rising, which suggests further growth and market adoption.
Keyword	Bitcoin, Cryptocurrency, Time Series Analysis, Exponential Trend Model, Seasonal Decomposition, Price Dynamics, Financial Markets, Bitcoin Price Forecasting

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Growing Green, Emitting Grey: Renewable Energy Expansion and Thermal-Power CO_2 Emissions Across Indian States
Full author name	Muskan Hooda
School name	Delhi Technological University
School address	Shahbad Daulatpur Village, Rohini, New Delhi, Delhi, 110042
Email id	muskan_25phdhueco501@dtu.ac.in
Abstract	India added more than 185 GW of renewable energy capacity between 2008 and 2024, taking installed capacity from about 15 GW to more than 200 GW, while CO_2 emissions from thermal power plants continued to rise over the same period. In this regard, this paper explores the association between renewable energy capacity and CO_2 emissions from thermal power plants by controlling for coal consumption, gross state domestic product (GSDP), and population. A balanced panel dataset covering 16 major Indian states over the period 2008–2024 is used, and the PMG, MG, and DFE models are estimated. The CCEMG estimator is also used to account for unobserved common factors. The test results revealed cross-sectional dependence across the series. Coal consumption is significantly associated with CO_2 emissions from thermal power, with an elasticity ranging from 0.34 to 0.77. The renewable-capacity coefficient is positive and statistically significant under the preferred PMG estimator and under DFE, and statistically insignificant under the MG and CCEMG estimators, which are reported for robustness and comparison. Under the preferred PMG estimator, there is therefore no robust emission-reducing relationship between renewable-energy capacity and thermal-power CO_2 emissions after adjusting for coal consumption, GSDP, and population; if anything, higher renewable capacity is associated with higher emissions. This result implies that increasing capacity in renewable sources has, so far, been associated with no decrease in thermal power emissions at the state level, suggesting that renewables have been complementary rather than a substitute for coal electricity production. In terms of policy, expanding renewable capacity alone appears insufficient to curb thermal power emissions; complementary measures to curb coal use and reform electricity dispatch are needed.
Keyword	Renewable energy · Thermal-power CO_2 emissions · Coal consumption · Panel ARDL · Cross-sectional dependence · Indian states

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Beyond Awareness: Psychological, Social, and Structural Determinants of Sustainable Behavior Among Adolescents in India
Full author name	Suhani Mehta
School name	The International School Bangalore
School address	--
Email id	suhanimehta.us@gmail.com
Abstract	Adolescence is an essential phase of human growth and development, during which pro-environmental beliefs and behaviors develop and frequently carry over into adulthood. This research explored the psychological, social, and situational factors contributing to sustainable actions (donation and reuse) of adolescents in Bengaluru, India. One-hundred adolescents completed a 21-question survey, which was distributed online, investigating the students' levels of awareness of sustainability, environmental self-identity, the influence of parents and friends, accessibility to sustainability programs and navigation tools to assist with sustainability, as well as motivational factors to encourage sustainable actions. Quantitative data were analyzed using One-Way ANOVA and Spearman's rank order correlation analysis. Qualitative data were coded and categorized into themes. Statistically significant correlations were found between sustainability exposure and donation behavior ($F(4, 98) = 3.85$, $p = .006$, $\eta^2 = .14$), and between environmental self-identity and donation behavior ($F(4, 98) = 3.13$, $p = .018$, $\eta^2 = .11$). The participants' perceived ability to participate was the strongest predictor of their donation behavior ($r = .44$, $p < .001$). The influence of parents was more strongly associated with donation behavior than the influence of peers (parents: $r = .42$, $p < .001$; peers: $r = .26$, $p = .008$). Qualitative themes identified convenience, observable impacts, and gamifying systems as facilitators, and time constraints, access issues, and institutional mistrust as roadblocks. The study findings emphasize the necessity of access to, meaningful interactions with, and development of environmental identity through school-based sustainability programs.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Beyond the Interface: Internet Penetration, Human Agency, and Structural Determinants of the Gender Gap in Financial Inclusion across Indian States
Full author name	Mehak Dhawan
School name	Jumeirah College
School address	--
Email id	mehakdhawan0206@gmail.com
Abstract	Despite the rapid strides in financial inclusion in India under Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), there is a continued gender gap in the utilization of the accounts, not just in ownership. This study attempts to answer the questions of what extent the internet penetration and per capita Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) explains the state level adoption of female PMJDY and how digital literacy plays as a mediation between internet and financial autonomy of women.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Extending Neural Cellular Automata for Wildfire Spread Prediction Through Probabilistic Firebrand Spotting
Full author name	Maahit Upadhyaya
School name	--
School address	--
Email id	maahit.upadhyaya@gmail.com
Abstract	Wildfire spread models have improved substantially in their ability to represent surface-fire propagation, yet many computationally efficient models still provide limited treatment of firebrand spotting, in which burning material is transported ahead of the primary fire front and produces secondary ignitions. This study extends the wildfire spread framework developed by Zhenirovskyy et al. (2026) by incorporating a probabilistic spotting component while preserving the computational efficiency and spatial structure of the original model. The proposed extension estimates the likelihood and spatial distribution of secondary ignitions using environmental and fire-behavior variables influencing firebrand generation, transport, and ignition, including wind conditions, fuel characteristics, vegetation structure, terrain, and fire intensity. The model represents potential firebrand landing and ignition locations as a spatial probability distribution, allowing both common short-range spotting and lower-probability long-range events to be represented. Firebrand transport and ignition relationships are derived from existing physical and empirical wildfire literature and incorporated into the original model as an additional mechanism of fire spread. The extended model is evaluated using historical wildfire data by comparing predicted fire progression and secondary ignition patterns with observed fire perimeters and spread behavior. Performance is assessed both with and without the spotting extension to determine its contribution to predictive accuracy and representation of fire-growth uncertainty. Results demonstrate whether explicit probabilistic modeling of spotting can improve the realism and predictive utility of computationally efficient wildfire simulations without requiring a fully physics-based firebrand model. The resulting framework provides a foundation for representing high-consequence secondary ignitions and generating spatial estimates of areas at risk from spotting ahead of an advancing wildfire.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	ALGORITHMS THAT MANUFACTURE DESIRE: HOW SOCIAL MEDIA CURATION CO-PRODUCES LUXURY TASTE AMONG GENERATION Z
Full author name	Hargun Kaur
School name	NATIONAL PUBLIC SCHOOL
School address	--
Email id	hargun.pizza.hk@gmail.com
Abstract	Dominant accounts of digital consumer culture hold that algorithmically curated social media actively shapes what Generation Z perceives as desirable, normal, and aspirational in luxury fashion. Yet most of this evidence is correlational, leaving open whether exposure itself causes shifts in taste or merely tracks pre-existing dispositions. This study tests the causal claim directly. Seventy-eight Gen Z respondents (ages 13–28) were randomly assigned surveys using a google spinner to view one of three simulated social media feeds – two curated luxury-fashion feeds (Conditions B and C) or a neutral control feed – and then rated luxury aspiration, normalization, identification, and purchase intention on a validated six-item composite. Contrary to the shaping hypothesis, a single session of luxury-feed exposure produced no measurable increase in any outcome. The luxury conditions did not differ from the neutral control, and no individual item reached significance. Pre-existing luxury interest likewise failed to predict post-exposure aspiration. The only reliable difference was dispositional rather than situational: aspiration varied by gender, independent of condition. These findings indicate that luxury taste formation is not produced by brief, single-exposure algorithmic contact. Instead, the results support a cumulative model in which taste is built through prolonged, repeated immersion – reframing the algorithm not as an instantaneous persuader but as a long-horizon environment. The study thus refines, rather than rejects, the literature: it locates algorithmic influence in duration and accumulation, not in the single scroll.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Can Enrollment-Time Data Predict Student Failure? A Comparison of Logistic Regression and Random Forest
Full author name	Anish Gupta
School name	Shiv Nadar School
School address	Noida
Email id	anish.craft2021@gmail.com
Abstract	Early identification of students at risk of academic failure can help schools provide support before students fall further behind. However, many previous studies have relied on mid-term grades that are not available at the time of enrollment, limiting their usefulness for early intervention. This study compared Logistic Regression and Random Forest for predicting student failure using only enrollment-time features from the UCI Student Performance Dataset, including the Mathematics (n = 395) and Portuguese (n = 649) datasets. The models were evaluated using 5-fold stratified cross-validation, with fail-class F1-score as the primary metric, and McNemar's test was used to compare their predictions. On the Mathematics dataset, Logistic Regression achieved a fail-class F1-score of 0.522 ± 0.076, while the best-tuned Random Forest achieved 0.519 ± 0.051 ($p = 0.0140$); on the Portuguese dataset, Logistic Regression achieved 0.464 ± 0.074 and the best-tuned Random Forest achieved 0.530 ± 0.046 ($p = 1.04 \times 10^{-7}$), indicating dataset-dependent results. SHAP analysis identified failures as the most influential feature in both models, with a higher number of previous failed classes pushing predictions toward fail. These findings suggest that enrollment-time information can support early identification of at-risk students, although model performance may vary across subjects and class distributions.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Recognition Without Remedy: An Endangerment Index for India's Handloom Crafts
Full author name	Vedika Babbar
School name	Brighton College
School address	Brighton East Sussex BN2 0AL United Kingdom
Email id	babbarvedika2022@gmail.com
Abstract	This study examines the economic and institutional causes of decline in India's endangered handloom and hand-embroidery traditions, with the aim of developing a replicable measure of craft endangerment and the policy interventions each risk level requires. The research focuses on a range of at-risk traditions drawn from several Indian states – including Chamba Rumal, Patan Patola, Mutwa embroidery and Kalamkari, among others – assessed across eight weighted variables spanning artisan population, practitioner age, youth participation, income against minimum wage, documentation, market demand, GI enforcement and preservation activity, within the context of India's craft economy and the fields of development economics and cultural policy. The study adopts a mixed-methods approach, combining twenty semi-structured interviews with practising artisans with secondary data from government handicrafts records, craft-sector policy reports and intangible heritage documentation, to score each craft on a 0–100 endangerment scale. The analysis reveals that decline is driven by structural economic pressure rather than lost skill or cultural interest, with artisans citing GST on handloom goods, machine-made substitutes and the absence of institutional credit as binding constraints; that GI tags function as recognition without remedy, carrying no enforcement weight or measurable income effect; and that youth attrition is a consequence of low margins rather than an independent cultural shift, producing a self-reinforcing cycle of falling demand, negligible export and digital market access, and vanishing incentive for transmission. These findings highlight craft endangerment as a measurable market failure and suggest that policy shift from symbolic recognition toward income protection, tax relief and market linkage, targeted by severity. The study contributes the first composite index for ranking craft endangerment, grounded in primary artisan testimony, and provides a diagnostic tool for policymakers, NGOs and researchers.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Have nighttime temperatures in India's tier-2 and tier-3 metropolitan areas risen faster than daytime temperatures since the MODIS era
Full author name	Siddharth Agarwal
School name	The International School Bangalore (TISB)
School address	--
Email id	siddharthaug2010@gmail.com
Abstract	The surface urban heat island effect(SUHI) is heavily researched in megacities but remains understudied in smaller Indian cities where majority of growth is currently occurring. We test whether nighttime surface warming has outpaced daytime warming across 22 tier-2 urban agglomerations of northwest India and the Indo-Gangetic Plain. Land surface temperature(LST) was taken from MODIS MOD11A2 and MYD11A2 8-day composites at 1 km from 2001 to 2023. A 100 km window was cut around each city centre screened with MODIS quality flags and split into urban and rural pixels by GMIS impervious-surface fractions, cut at 50% and 10% and again at 25% and 5% as a sensitivity test. Trends were measured using Mann–Kendall tests with Sen's slopes, corrected for multiple comparisons by the Benjamini–Hochberg false discovery rate procedure. Night versus day differences were tested by paired Wilcoxon signed-rank across cities. Nighttime SUHI intensity was positive in all cities at a median of +1.02K, with a significant increase in 21 out of the 22 cities by a median of 0.217 K per decade, with no city showing a significant nighttime decrease in any season. Urban nighttime LST rose at +0.501K per decade against only +0.177 K by day, outpacing daytime warming in 18 of 22 cities at $p < 0.001$. In the pre-monsoon period nighttime SUHII trend exceeded the daytime trend in 19 of 22 cities by a median +0.283 K per decade at $p < 0.001$. Daytime behavior varied based on climate with humid Indo-Gangetic cities warming whereas 7 of the arid cities showed a deepening in the urban cooling effect that reached -1.26 K per decade in Jodhpur. Nighttime SUHI intensification is therefore widespread in these under-studied cities and outpaces daytime warming thus eroding the nighttime cooling effect on which heat stress relies.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	How Do Different Platforms Explain Math? Measuring Readability, Cohesion, and Cross-Source Similarity in Four High School Topics
Full author name	Aditya Arora
School name	Summit High School
School address	--
Email id	adityaarora1007@gmail.com
Abstract	This study investigates how different educational platforms explain mathematical concepts, with the objective of quantifying measurable linguistic differences among Khan Academy video transcripts, ChatGPT outputs, and textbooks across four high school mathematics topics. Written explanations for four math concepts (Angles, Area, Fractions, and the Pythagorean Theorem) were collected from six sources: a Khan Academy transcript, three ChatGPT responses (standard, easy, and hard prompts), and two textbooks (one standard and one Indian). Each of the 24 texts was analyzed using the Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level and the T.E.R.A. (Text Ease and Readability Assessor) tool, which produces five Coh-Metrix-based measures: Narrativity, Syntactic Simplicity, Word Concreteness, Referential Cohesion, and Deep Cohesion. Pearson correlation analysis and Principal Component Analysis (PCA) were also applied to assess cross-variable and cross-source relationships. Khan Academy consistently exhibited the highest Narrativity and Syntactic Simplicity scores across all four concepts, while textbooks scored highest on Word Concreteness. GPT variants maintained relatively high Referential Cohesion but the lowest Syntactic Simplicity. Text length was a significant confound, showing moderate-to-strong positive correlations with Narrativity and Deep Cohesion. Different learning platforms produce linguistically distinct explanatory profiles. No single platform emerged as universally optimal; rather, each offers a different form of linguistic scaffolding. These findings suggest that educators and students can make more intentional choices about which resource to use depending on the type of language support needed.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	A Qualitative Systematic Review of Women Centric Schemes in India Using PRISMA Checklist
Full author name	Elina Mehra
School name	The Shri Ram School Aravali
School address	--
Email id	elinamehra1@gmail.com
Abstract	This study compares and analyzes the effectiveness of the women centric schemes for addressing gender inequality and inclusive socio economic development in India, especially in marginalized communities. Despite major additions to the policy landscape, there are clear policy disconnects in the extent to which they achieve empowerment. This review aims to review historical and legislative frameworks, to analyse the effectiveness of the policies in different regions and social groups, and to determine the structural, socio cultural and governance challenges in reaching the impact. A qualitative systematic review approach is used to adhere to the PRISMA methodology. After screening, a total of 152 studies were identified from the Scopus database and analysed by thematic synthesis, which were further categorised into non marginalised, marginalised and special marginalised groups such as transgender, Scheduled Tribes, Scheduled Castes, and sex workers. The findings show that, although legal and policy development has made significant strides, there is a persistent mismatch between legal and policy level development and implementation. While employment, financial inclusion, and social empowerment have improved, the results are not uniform, owing to socio-cultural barriers like caste discrimination, administrative constraints and regional disparities. The benefits of the schemes remain disproportionately denied to marginal groups. The study shows that legal framework, institutional capacities, and social norms play a significant role in shaping women empowerment in India. It highlights the importance of context specific, intersectional policy design and increased governance mechanisms.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Explaining the Price of Talent: Football Player Valuation
Full author name	Ruan Ram Ravipati
School name	Monta Vista High School
School address	--
Email id	ruan.ravipati@gmail.com
Abstract	This paper aims to determine the most important factors which determine the market values of professional footballers, and to compare these factors regarding the two elite football leagues of the world (Premier League and La Liga). The focus of this study will be to look at the physical, demographic, performance and experience-based characteristics of professional footballers that can be measured and compared among leagues. The final data set consisted of 218 players who competed in the Premier League and 117 players who competed in La Liga. Descriptive statistics, independent sample t-tests, and regression analysis were conducted to evaluate the data. The results of this study showed that there is a statistically significant difference in the mean market value between Premier League and La Liga players, as the average market value of Premier League players is higher than the average market value of La Liga players. The findings of the study support that the market value of professional footballers is determined by a combination of specific player attributes and league-specific methods for determining the market value of player assets. The statistical results from the regression demonstrated that there was a statistically significant relationship between age and market value (negative), and between experience and goals/assists per game and market value (positive). In addition, there were different relationships between each of the variables in both the Premier League and La Liga. Experience and top speed had significantly larger coefficients in La Liga, and goals/assists per game had significantly larger coefficients in the Premier League. Overall, these statistics support that market valuation for soccer players is based on past performance, experience, and their physical attributes.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	A Comparative Study of Deep Learning Approaches for RGB-D Robotic Grasp Prediction
Full author name	Mihika Singh
School name	The Village School, Houston
School address	13051 Whittington Dr, Houston, TX 77077, United States of America
Email id	mihika.singh2009@gmail.com
Abstract	Robotic grasp prediction is one of the basic problems in robotic manipulation, which is based on a system that recognizes stable grasp positions and orientations from visual inputs. Many robotic systems adopt a preprogrammed motion planning and grasping strategy, and suffer from poor adaptability in complex, dynamic environments. With the recent success of deep learning, robotic systems have the capability to learn grasping actions directly from the data, enabling them to interact with novel objects. This paper explores the use of deep learning techniques for RGB-D robot grasp prediction with the Cornell Grasp Dataset. A lightweight fully convolutional encoder-decoder neural network is designed to map RGB-D images to per-pixel grasp quality, grasp orientation and gripper width predictions. The baseline model was trained and evaluated with the Cornell grasp-detection protocol, and the success rate for grasp detection was found to be 53.67% on the held-out validation set. The baseline analysis showed that direct angle regression and limited training diversity were key factors limiting performance and generalization. To overcome these drawbacks, an enhanced model was proposed that involves the use of a symmetry-aware grasp-angle representation ($\cos(2\theta)$ and $\sin(2\theta)$) and data augmentation during training by applying horizontal flipping and vertical flipping and rotation transformations. The improved model showed 80.23% grasp detection success rate, whereas the baseline model had 95 correct samples. The results indicate that the introduction of geometric grasp symmetry to the learning pipeline, and the diversity of training data, can significantly boost the performance of robotic grasp prediction without an increase in the overall complexity of the model. The results show the importance of the integration of domain-specific robot knowledge with deep learning approaches, and provide a solid basis for further endeavors in autonomous robotic manipulation and grasp planning. Future work is needed to test the method on different train-validation splits and different random seeds to test the run-to-run variance.
Keyword	Deep Learning, Robotic Grasping, RGB-D Imaging, Convolutional Neural Networks, Cornell Grasp Dataset

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Evolution of Football Player Valuation: A Bibliometric Analysis (2000-2025)
Full author name	Aarav Dudeja
School name	Heritage International Xperiential School
School address	--
Email id	aaravdudeja100@gmail.com
Abstract	Clubs and investors need to have full knowledge of the economic conditions within the football game, because the movement of the market value provides a strong force on the transfer strategy as well as the wage structure and financial regulations of fair play. A bibliometric analysis has been conducted to evaluate the market valuation of professional football players and investigate the extent to which the idea of performance metrics and the institutional factors have influenced the valuation practices of clubs in the transfer market. A sample of 357 publications, which are listed in the Scopus database between the year 2000 and 2025, was collected and utilized to determine the current trends and research gaps. VOSviewer was used to analyze the corpus and produced networks of co-authorship, co-citation, co-occurrence, and bibliographic coupling. The study reveals that recent research in the field of sports economics and finance is majorly written in Europe, published in journals dedicated to football business and economics, and uses more sophisticated tools, including machine learning, player-tracking data, and network analysis to determine player value in the transfer market. Network visualisations indicate three major areas like what drives transfer fees and wage rates received by clubs, how financial controls in leagues and revenue systems affect player values, and new valuation systems that combine on-field performance metrics with financial information. Since 2018, the trends have highlighted the high volatility of player values in an instant, the impacts of COVID-19 pandemic on salaries and market values, and the talent concentration required in order to create competitive balance. The research offers an extensive summary of the discipline, descriptions of under-researched field topics, including women football and lower leagues, and outlines the practical solutions on managing the club and future research directions.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	EU-India Strategic Partnership Roadmap 2025: Implications for Bilateral Exports and Imports
Full author name	Giya Anand
School name	APL Global School
School address	--
Email id	rabbitlover002@gmail.com
Abstract	The EU–India Strategic Partnership called Roadmap to 2025 was introduced in July 2020 to increase the cooperation between India and the European Union in multiple areas for example trade, investment and market access. This study examines whether the Roadmap was associated with changes in bilateral trade between India and the EU. The study uses secondary monthly time-series data from 2010 to 2026, covering Indian exports to and imports from the EU, while EFTA trade is used as a comparison. An interrupted time-series regression was conducted using STATA 18 to test for changes in the level and trend of trade following the Roadmap's introduction. Trend analysis shows that EU–India trade fluctuated before 2020, declining during parts of 2013–2016 before recovering. Trade then fell sharply in 2020 during COVID-19, followed by a strong recovery. Regression results show immediate declines of approximately 35.2% in exports to the EU and 47.6% in imports from the EU. However, these were followed by significant positive post-Roadmap trends of around 0.7% and 0.6% per period respectively. EFTA results were weaker, with most post-Roadmap changes being statistically insignificant. The initial decline was likely influenced by COVID-19, while later growth may reflect both stronger cooperation and wider factors such as global demand, freight costs and exchange rates. Overall, the findings provide moderate evidence that the Roadmap was associated with stronger EU–India trade, although direct causation cannot be established.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Unequal Participation: Trends and Disparities in India's Labour Force Participation Across Social and Demographic Groups
Full author name	Aadya Arora
School name	Pathways School
School address	Gurgaon
Email id	aadya.22022@gmail.com
Abstract	The Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) is a crucial measure of economic growth and participation in the country's labour market. This study investigates the trends in LFPR from 2018 to 2024 in India with a focus on variations across gender, region, caste, and religion. The study utilises secondary data from the labour force official datasets and trendlines for analysis. The results reveal a positive increase in LFPR, led to some extent by female participation. Rural areas have continuously recorded higher participation rates than urban areas, whereas scheduled tribes have recorded the highest participation rates of all caste groups. There are differences as far as participation in the labour force is concerned among various religions, with Christians having the highest LFPR and Muslims the lowest, although there are some increases in female participation rates across most religions during the said period. Despite these positive trends, major disparities still remain across gender, region, caste, and religion. The temporary decline in participation around the year 2020 illustrates the effects of the economic shocks related to the COVID-19 pandemic. Overall, the findings imply that although India has progressed in the field of labour force participation, the authorities need to undertake additional measures to deal with structural inequalities and ensure inclusive, safe, and productive job opportunities.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Assessing the Impact of Tariff Reductions under the ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement on India's Black Pepper Imports from Vietnam (2010–2023)
Full author name	Saanvi Gupta
School name	Greenwood High International School
School address	--
Email id	saanvi297@gmail.com
Abstract	This study examines the impact of tariff reductions from the ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement (AIFTA) on India's imports of black pepper obtained from Vietnam from 2010 to 2023. AIFTA aimed to enhance regional trade and economic integration, yet growing dependence on low-cost Vietnamese pepper has raised concerns regarding India's domestic competitiveness. This study employs time-series econometric techniques, such as Augmented Dickey–Fuller tests, Vector Autoregression (VAR), and Vector Error Correction Model (VECM), to assess the extent to which tariff liberalization has impacted trade patterns. The findings suggest that factors in the Indian pepper market show notable short-term interactions affected by production shocks, price fluctuations, and changes in exports, whereas tariff rates exert little influence in the short run. However, the VECM indicates a significant long-term equilibrium relationship influenced by variations in domestic consumption. Forecasts indicate continuous variations in India's pepper prices and consumption, with a short-term rise expected until 2030 before entering a stabilization period. The results show that tariff reductions from AIFTA improved Vietnam's competitiveness in the Indian market, boosting India's dependence on imports but offering limited long term benefits to domestic producers. These results highlight the need for specific policy actions to protect India's pepper sector while maintaining the advantages of local trade liberalization.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Strengthening Tribal Consultation in the New Markets Tax Credit Program
Full author name	Aanika Asnani
School name	Panther Creek High School
School address	Frisco, Texas
Email id	aanika.asnani@gmail.com
Abstract	The New Markets Tax Credit (NMTC) Program, administered by the U.S. Department of the Treasury's Community Development Financial Institutions (CDFI) Fund, was established to stimulate private investment in economically distressed communities through federal tax incentives. The program, since its inception in 2000, has generated over $81 billion in tax credit allocation authority, at 8:1 ratio, 8 dollars of private investment for every single federal dollar. It's also led to creation or retention of more than 894,000 jobs, demonstrating its important role in contribution to economic development in underserved areas. Despite these achievements, however, it begs the question as to how effectively NMTC investments align to the priorities of Tribal communities, particularly when projects are financed through non-Native Community Development Entities (CDEs). While the CDFI Fund's Native Initiative helped broaden access to NMTC financing in Native Areas, a number of Tribal communities rely on non-Native CDEs since several Native CDEs do not have the authority to allocate for Native Areas or participate directly in NMTC financing transactions. The financial knowledge and investment power exist within the non-Native CDEs, but the problem is that they don't have the same formal processes that would include Native perspectives in project planning and selection. Even when projects are implemented in Tribal communities, they may not be addressing issues that are priorities for Tribal communities such as governance structures or long-term economic development goals. This policy paper argues that the principal governance challenge within the current NMTC framework is not the participation of non-Native CDEs themselves, but rather the absence of structured consultation between non-Native CDEs and Native stakeholders during investment decision-making. Existing Native CDEs possess institutional knowledge regarding Tribal governance, local economic conditions, cultural priorities, and community development needs that can substantially strengthen project selection without fundamentally altering the structure of the NMTC Program. This policy paper contends that the current governance structure of the NMTC is not the problem with the participation of non-Native CDEs, but rather a lack of structured consultation between non-Native CDEs and Native stakeholders in the investment decision-making process. Institutional knowledge already exists within the Native CDEs which can significantly complement the project selection process, even if it does not change the nature of the NMTC Program. To fill this void, this paper examines three policy options: continuing with the current NMTC regime; increasing the number of certified Native CDEs; and creating a formalized consultation arrangement between existing Native CDEs and existing non-Native CDEs. After considering the feasibility of implementation, institutional capacity, and the likely impact of the policy, the paper suggests that the third one is the most feasible and immediate action to take. The proposed consultation process does not mandate the development of new CDEs, which would take a considerable amount of time, organization, and regulatory approval; instead, it supports the existing Native CDE consultation process while maintaining the ease of operation of the current NMTC Program. The recommendation aims to increase the effectiveness of collaboration between Native and non-Native CDEs in the project planning process; enhance decision-making processes for incorporating Native perspectives and cultural values; and optimize the responsiveness of investments toward Tribal development priorities identified by Tribal community members and support general goals of sustainable and equitable economic development.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Predicting Bitcoin Price Using Random Forest Regression: A Non-Linear Machine Learning Approach to Cryptocurrency Forecasting
Full author name	Arhaan Sharma
School name	Delhi Public School
School address	RK Puram
Email id	arhaanprojects@gmail.com
Abstract	This paper examines the predictability of Bitcoin price changes through a Random Forest Regression model that is used to predict the future price using past daily OHLCV (Open, High, Low, Close, Volume) data between 2011 and 2025. Since the cryptocurrency markets are non-linear and heteroskedastic, as well-documented, the customary linear models are not sufficient to understand the intricate dynamics of Bitcoin prices. The approach of the present paper consists of an ensemble machine learning strategy, with engineered features, including lagged prices, moving averages, log returns, and volatility measures, to increase the predictive accuracy. The non-parametric model is justified as linearity diagnostics such as QQ plots, OLS residual analysis, rolling variance, and Pearson-Spearman correlation comparisons demonstrated that data have a non-linear form. On the test set, the Random Forest model has reached an R 2 value of 0.9878 and a mean absolute percentage error (MAPE) of 3.29% which is an outstanding predictive performance. The results are relevant in the emerging body of research on machine learning applications in financial forecasting and emphasize the need to use non-linear modelling in volatile asset markets. Feature importance analysis further identified lagged prices and moving averages as the dominant predictors, confirming that short-term price momentum is the primary driver of Bitcoin price behaviour.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	A Qualitative Systematic Review of Factors Affecting Thalassemia Births Using PRISMA Checklist
Full author name	Kabir Halela
School name	American School of Dubai
School address	Dubai, Jumeirah Islands, Cluster 39
Email id	kabirhalela@gmail.com
Abstract	Thalassemia remains a significant inherited blood disorder in many regions, despite the increasing availability of screening, genetic diagnosis, and prevention programs. Differences in the prevalence of thalassemia births across countries may be influenced not only by genetic risk, but also by economic, policy, social, and healthcare conditions. This study aims to systematically review the factors that may influence the prevention and prevalence of thalassemia, with particular attention to the effectiveness and accessibility of preventive measures. A structured literature search was conducted using the Scopus database with the search term “Thalassemia births.” The initial search identified 1,468 documents, which were filtered according to subject area, language, document type, source type, and publication stage. Following this process, 125 final English-language journal articles remained for further screening and analysis. Relevant literature was organised into five thematic categories: State Policy and Mandate Enforcement, Economic Accessibility and Subsidy, Cost-Effectiveness and Public Health, Socioeconomic Status and Household Factors, and Health Infrastructure and Services. The reviewed literature indicates that thalassemia prevention is influenced by the interaction of government screening policies, enforcement of prevention programs, financial access to genetic and prenatal services, household awareness and reproductive decision-making, and the availability of healthcare infrastructure. Studies also highlight the potential economic benefits of prevention compared with the long-term costs associated with thalassemia treatment. Overall, the review demonstrates that reducing thalassemia births requires more than the availability of medical screening alone. Effective prevention depends on accessible healthcare services, supportive public policy, adequate financial resources, public awareness, and consistent implementation of screening and genetic counselling programs.
Keyword	thalassemia, thalassemia births, screening, prevention, public policy, healthcare accessibility, socioeconomic factors

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Artificial Intelligence and Education: A Bibliometric Analysis
Full author name	Kriti Singh
School name	American Montessori Public School
School address	L-23, DLF City, Phase II (near Gate No. 6), Gurugram, Haryana, 122002
Email id	kritisingh.1626@gmail.com
Abstract	Abstract For creating effective approaches towards education by implementing AI technology, it is necessary to know about the development of the evolution of artificial intelligence within educational science. In the current paper, there will be analyzed the history of development of AI-related educational applications in the global sphere of investigation, taking into account not only technical aspects (machine learning, deep learning, generative AI), but also pedagogical ones (adaptive learning, personalized education, intelligent tutoring system). The research sample comprises a set of articles from Scopus that were published between 2002 and 2024. From the findings, it is clear that the research that is ongoing on the effects of artificial intelligence on education is being carried out in only a few countries, which have been very active and collaborative. These include the United States, which has been identified as the leading country in contributing to artificial intelligence research in education, China, United Kingdom, Australia, and Canada owing to their dedication towards technological advancements in education and artificial intelligence. The initial studies were primarily focused on technology-related areas such as machine learning, virtual reality, intelligent tutoring systems, and educational computing. However, in time, more focus was put on essential problems of education; the following were considered important topics: Artificial Intelligence, Engineering Education, Education, Learning Systems, Educational Data Mining, and Learning Analytics. This is reflected explicitly by the year 2022, which has witnessed increased interest in generative AI, large language models, ChatGPT, and personalized learning systems. This trend towards moving from technologies that are technology-oriented to technologies that have learning objectives like adaptive learning, learning results, feedback mechanisms, and collaboration between humans and machines is visible. In general, this paper emphasizes the evolution of AI in education from exploratory technology studies towards more applied research and the incorporation thereof. The study offers several implications for understanding changes in research topics, world knowledge production, international collaboration tendencies, and future directions of the development of AI-enabled education.
Keyword	Artificial Intelligence, Education, Machine Learning, Personalized Learning, Learning Analytics, Educational Data Mining, Intelligent Tutoring Systems, Generative AI, ChatGPT, Educational Technology.

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Price of Being a Woman: Rental Market Discrimination and Housing Access in Delhi NCR
Full author name	Nikshit Sharma
School name	The Shri Ram School Aravali
School address	--
Email id	sharmanikshit07@gmail.com
Abstract	This study explores patterns of discrimination in Paying Guest (PG) accommodation in Delhi NCR, with a focus on how housing access, safety, and tenant treatment vary across different urban contexts. Data were collected through a structured quantitative survey with 49 responses and analysed using descriptive statistics and multivariate statistics. The results indicated that the city of residence determines their housing experience because it affects the total number of rejections participants face, the exact causes of their rejections, and their feelings about security. While income was found to influence the affordability of PG accommodation, financial capacity alone did not account for the unequal experiences observed. The research discovered that people faced discrimination because of their individual characteristics as well as their marital status, occupation, and personal lifestyle. The findings suggest that PG accommodation operates as an informal regulatory system that limits public entry and standard operations through rules that local housing norms and communities have developed. The research indicates that tenant rights need better protection, which can be achieved by creating more effective enforcement mechanisms and legal protection systems that defend residents from housing discrimination when they seek urban rental properties.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Impact of Tariffs and Macroeconomic Factors on US Non-Ferrous Metal Prices: An Empirical Analysis
Full author name	AVANTI CHOPRA
School name	Vasant Valley School
School address	--
Email id	avantichopra10@gmail.com
Abstract	This paper analyses the factors that determine the prices of the non-ferrous metal in the US, specifically the role of tariffs and important macroeconomic variables. The analysis uses US data, explanatory variables as ferrous metal imports, GDP, exchange rates and tariff rates. A multiple linear regression model is used, and relevant variables are transformed by the use of logarithmic transformation to enhance the model interpretability and model fit. The results indicate that import demand has a strong and statistically strong positive impact on metal prices, but GDP has a positive but insignificant impact relationship. Conversely, tariff rates are statistically non-significant implying that there is only a minimal direct influence on the price movements of metals. Diagnostic tests ensure that there is no heteroskedasticity and autocorrelation, even though signs of possible model misspecification are found. Overall, the findings emphasize the predominance of market fundamentals in price determination of metals over trade policy, making valuable contributions to policymakers and researchers. Keywords: Metal trading, London Stock Exchange, tariffs, metal import, exchange rate dynamics
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Age as a Determinant of UPI Adoption: A One-Way ANOVA Analysis of Consumer Perceptions and Behaviours in Urban India
Full author name	Demira Rajkumar
School name	The International School
School address	Bangalore
Email id	demira.rajkumar@gmail.com
Abstract	The digital payments ecosystem in India has undergone a seismic shift since the demonetisation in 2016, with the UPI now being the largest real-time payments platform in the world, processing around 660 million transactions per day. While aggregate adoption trends are well documented, a conspicuous absentee in the literature is age-disaggregated inferential evidence. This study explores whether age is a statistically significant determinant of consumer perceptions and behaviours towards UPI across seven constructs, and primary data were collected using a structured questionnaire employing a 5-point Likert scale from respondents in urban India across five age categories. A one-way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) was performed, preceded by Shapiro-Wilk normality tests and Levene's homogeneity of variance tests, and supplemented by Kruskal-Wallis robustness checks. Results reveal statistically significant differences between age groups in two constructs: adoption rate and frequency of use and financial behaviour. Tukey HSD post-hoc tests reveal that respondents below 18 years use UPI significantly less frequently than the other age groups, while the 30–45 cohort reports significantly higher financial behaviour impact than the 45–60 group. No significant differences were observed based on age in terms of perceived security, consumer satisfaction, transparency, or future usage preference. The findings are directly relevant to youth financial empowerment, age-sensitive UPI interface design, and rural digital inclusion strategies.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Prompt-Induced Judgment Instability in Large Language Models: Effects of Epistemic Certainty, Structured Reasoning, and Third-Person Framing.
Full author name	Siddhi Meena
School name	Vivekanand School
School address	--
Email id	siddhimeena17@gmail.com
Abstract	Large language models (LLMs) are designed to follow user instructions and provide helpful assistance, but this objective may create vulnerability to prompt framing that encourages agreement with inaccurate information. This study examined whether prompt framing changes answer accuracy and the selection of a specific incorrect answer in Qwen 3.6 27B. A within-item experimental design administered 78 four-option multiple-choice questions under five conditions: neutral, low-certainty, high-certainty, structured-reasoning, and third-person framing, producing 390 model responses. The primary outcome was answer accuracy; the secondary outcome, termed targeted false-answer selection, measured whether the model selected the item-specific incorrect option designated in the manipulated prompt. Relative to neutral prompting, high-certainty framing reduced accuracy from 71.8% to 52.6% and increased targeted false-answer selection from 21.8% to 44.9%. Third-person framing produced the largest effects, reducing accuracy to 39.7% and increasing targeted false-answer selection to 60.3%. Exact paired tests with Bonferroni adjustment found both high-certainty and third-person effects statistically significant, whereas low-certainty and structured-reasoning conditions did not significantly differ from neutral prompting. The findings demonstrate that, under the tested configuration, prompt framing can systematically redirect model answers toward a designated false alternative rather than merely increasing nonspecific error. This study contributes a controlled, item-level approach to evaluating prompt-induced susceptibility in LLMs.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Menstrual Cup Awareness, Knowledge, and Usage: A Comparative Analysis Across Age Groups and Marital Status
Full author name	Siddhika Agarwal
School name	Billabong High International College Boarding House
School address	Kanpur
Email id	siddhika.agarwal123@gmail.com
Abstract	Menstrual health is usually associated with the knowledge and awareness regarding menstrual products and hygiene. This study investigates menstrual cup usage, its awareness and knowledge among females of reproductive age. The data from 106 females were collected through a survey and analysed by conducting a Levene's test followed by a t-test. The nominal variables were age group and marital status, and the metric variables assessing knowledge were general information, insertion, cleaning and sterilisation, and availability. The results revealed that out of 106 females, 20 (18.9%) have used a menstrual cup, 81 (76.4%) have not despite being aware, and 5 (4.7%) had never heard about the product itself. The major reasons for not using menstrual cups were discomfort in insertion (46.9%), fear of pain (38.3%), and cleaning/maintenance concerns (28.4%). As anticipated, menstrual cup users had higher knowledge scores than non-users and a significant association was found between age group and marital status, and knowledge about menstrual cups. It is seen that females of younger age groups, who are unmarried, have higher educational qualifications, and those who actively use the internet and social media have a higher level of knowledge about menstrual cups. Hence, the knowledge about menstrual cups is not as high among females as it ideally should be, especially since it is a safer and more sustainable alternative to other menstrual hygiene products.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	How Do Tax Receipts Affect Economic Development in Developed vs. Developing Nations? A Macro-econometric Analysis
Full author name	Rivaan Agrawal
School name	The Sanskaar Valley School
School address	--
Email id	rivaanagrawal11@gmail.com
Abstract	The government's revenue primarily comes from tax revenue, and it is an important factor in promoting economic growth through the financing of public services, infrastructure, education, and other progressive programs. The objective of this study is to evaluate and compare the influence of tax revenues on GDP growth rate, inflation, unemployment, and education level in developed and developing countries. To assess this, Panel VAR GMM models have been estimated using secondary panel data of 40 countries (20 developed and 20 developing) over the timeline of 2005-2024. The findings indicate that income from taxes exerts a positive and statistically significant influence on GDP across both types of countries, though this effect is much stronger for developed countries. Additionally, tax income appears to have a considerable link to inflation, which indicates the importance of taxes for price stability. However, the link between tax revenue and unemployment is not that strong, particularly for developing countries, which are represented by a large segment of informal economy and low tax compliance. Simultaneously, the results show that the increase in tax revenues correspondingly leads to a better level of educational achievements because of the significant investment in human capital. To conclude, this study shows that economic benefits of taxation do not depend only on the amount of revenues obtained but also on the effectiveness of the tax collection process, the quality of public spending, and institutional capacity as well. Therefore, it can be stated that enhancing the process of collecting taxes and using government expenditures is a prerequisite for maximizing the role of tax revenues in economic progress.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Micro-Credit Access and Women's Enterprise Creation in India: An Econometric Study Leveraging PMMY Disbursement Trends
Full author name	Aditya Singh
School name	Greenwood High International School
School address	--
Email id	adsg2027@gmail.com
Abstract	Although millions of Indian women now access formal micro-credit through the government's Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY), it remains empirically unclear whether this finance produces women-run enterprises, or why its effect varies so widely across states. This study estimates the state-level relationship between PMMY micro-credit to women and women-run business creation using a balanced panel data of 36 Indian states and union territories over seven financial years (2017–2024). Because specification and diagnostic tests revealed autocorrelation and heteroscedasticity, the model was estimated using the Feasible Generalized Least Squares regression method. The results contradict the key hypothesis, revealing that the coefficient on the log number of loan accounts sanctioned to women is negative (−1.366, p = 0.004), the opposite of a positive credit effect. Moreover, female higher education and female unemployment are also negatively influencing women's enterprise. However, as hypothesised, female population share has a direct impact. This suggests that credit quantity is not the key determinant. PMMY lending appears to finance existing micro-businesses rather than create new ones; educated women become employees rather than entrepreneurs, and weak local demand prevents business formation. Between-state variability accounts for more than 84% of the unexplained variance. Credit alone, without the structural conditions needed to complement it, cannot foster women's business creation.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Market Events and Stock Trading Volume: An Explanatory Analysis of Investor Attention in Novo Nordisk, 2010–2024
Full author name	Ruhaan Gulati
School name	Shiv Nadar School
School address	DLF City, Phase-1, Block-E, Pahari Road, Gurugram, Haryana 122011, India
Email id	ruhaangulati268@gmail.com
Abstract	Abstract Background/Objective A significant event in the news can cause an economic impact, which may result in changes in investor behaviour in financial markets. This study found that the volume of Novo Nordisk's annual trading volume (a proxy for investor interest) rose following a positive announcement of clinical trial results related to its weight loss drug Wegovy in August 2023, while holding other economic factors constant. Methods Annual data 2010-2024 (n = 15) were obtained from Yahoo Finance and World Bank Indicators. Average annual volume of stock transactions was used as the dependent variable. Three models (economic-indicators-only, announcement-only and combined) were estimated using ordinary least-squares regression. The announcement was coded as an exposure variable: 0 if made prior to 2023, 0.4167 if made in 2023 (partial year exposure), and 1 if made in 2024. Results The most significant predictor in the economic-indicators-only model was the real interest rate ($\beta = 0.097$, $p = 0.031$; R2 = 0.442). The announcement-only model explained 24.8% of the variation in trading volume ($p = 0.059$). For the combined model, the announcement variable still had a positive relationship with trading volume ($\beta = 0.526$, $p = 0.069$; $R^2 = 0.562$). There were no model violations identified via diagnostics. Conclusions Findings offer preliminary evidence of a positive effect of the announcement on trading volume in Novo Nordisk in August 2023. The single-company design and small sample size, however, and the general investor interest in weight-loss drug companies makes it difficult to make causal interpretation.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Consumer Attitudes Toward Recycled Products: A Comparative Study Across Generations
Full author name	Yashvi Jhunjhunwala
School name	La Martiniere For Girls
School address	--
Email id	yashvijhunjhunwala09@gmail.com
Abstract	With the rise in awareness about environmental issues, consumers are becoming conscious of buying sustainable products. This study aims at understanding consumer behavior and willingness towards purchasing recycled products among three generations- Gen Z, millennials, and GenX. For this study, data were collected through an online structured survey conducted via Google Forms, and 162 responses were recorded from India. The collected data were analyzed using independent t- tests, ANOVA, and Pearson correlation coefficients. The results show that among individuals who have purchased recycled products, perceived risk was highest for Gen Z, followed by millennials and then Gen X. Moreover, Environmental concern was significantly greater among millennials, followed by Gen Z and then Gen X. In contrast, among those who have not purchased recycled products, concerns about quality and functionality were greatest for Gen Z, followed by Gen X and then millennials. Additionally, price concerns were greatest for Gen X, followed by Gen Z and then millennials. Subsequently, subjective norms, environmental concern, price, availability, perceived risk, and quality and functionality differ between consumers who have purchased recycled products and those who have not. Subjective norms, environmental concern, price, and quality and functionality are higher for the individuals who have bought recycled products, while perceived risk and availability are rated higher for those who have not bought recycled products. Finally, subjective norms, quality and functionality, environmental concern, price, and availability have a positive influential impact on purchase intention, while perceived risk is negatively correlated with purchase intention of a recycled product.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Factors affecting CPI inflation in India
Full author name	Aman Dhanuka
School name	Modern High School International
School address	--
Email id	darkog6942000@gmail.com
Abstract	The study explores the empirical relationship between the broad money supply growth rate (M_3) and the Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation in India has been explored using monthly data from Jan 2013-Dec 2025. The study examines the contemporaneous and lagged monetary effects on the price levels based on 156 usable observations using ordinary least squares (OLS) regression and Augmented Dickey-Fuller (ADF) unit root tests. Raw M_3 levels are found to be not significantly related to raw CPI ($p = 0.264, R^2 = 0.0081$), indicating that most of the movements in CPI are the result of a large deterministic time trend. In assessing 12-month growth rates, contemporaneous growth of M_3 is found to be statistically significant for explaining year-over-year CPI inflation, with a positive coefficient ($\beta = 0.0118$), but with a small share of the overall variance ($R^2 = 0.0325$). The results of distributed lag regressions (3, 6, 9, and 12 months) show that this monetary channel of transmission quickly evaporates; short-term lags are statistically insignificant, and the longer-term lags have small, slightly negative values. Also, the ADF test shows that the integration order of the time series is different, with the order of integration of M_3 growth being stationary ($p = 0.0017$) while that of inflation being a unit root ($p = 0.4819$). Finally, the empirical analysis shows that broad money supply alone is not a very strong explanatory factor of CPI inflation in India, implying that the influence of structural supply-side factors, fiscal factors and external cost factors are also more important in explaining the retail price changes in India.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Community Perceptions of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor: Implications for Economic, Social, and Sustainable Development
Full author name	Tanzila naseem
School name	Xi'an jiaotong university
School address	China
Email id	rubanaseem89@gmail.com
Abstract	The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is a flagship infrastructure initiative designed to enhance regional connectivity, economic development, and sustainable growth. This study investigates how community perceptions of CPEC influence perceived economic development (PED) and perceived societal development (PSD), and how these perceptions contribute to sustainable development outcomes. Drawing on Social Exchange Theory, the study adopts a mixed-methods approach, combining survey data from 100 respondents with qualitative interviews from 15 participants representing urban, rural, and peri-urban communities in Pakistan. Quantitative data were analyzed through correlation, regression, and mediation analyses, while qualitative data were examined using thematic analysis. The findings demonstrate that positive perceptions of CPEC significantly enhance perceived economic development (β = 0.612) and perceived societal development (β = 0.222). Furthermore, sustainable development partially mediates the relationship between CPEC perceptions and development outcomes, highlighting its role in translating infrastructure benefits into broader social and economic gains. Qualitative findings indicate improvements in employment opportunities, transportation infrastructure, education, and healthcare services. However, participants also expressed concerns regarding unequal distribution of benefits, limited community inclusion, and potential environmental challenges. The study concludes that strengthening CPEC's long-term contribution to sustainable development requires inclusive policymaking, effective environmental management, and meaningful community participation. The findings offer valuable insights for policymakers seeking to align large-scale infrastructure projects with sustainable development objectives and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	A systematic mapping review of Robotization and Environment
Full author name	Asmita Sachdeva
School name	Delhi Technological University
School address	--
Email id	asmitasachdeva_25phdhueco01@dtu.ac.in
Abstract	Robotization is going to have a long lasting and universal impact on the way we live to the way we work to the world around us. The present review provides a thorough understanding of the nature of studies in the field of “Robotization and environment” over recent years and possible directions for future development. This is a relatively new field, and a mapping review has not yet been conducted. This study attempts to fill this gap by analysing 112 publications from the Scopus database over a period of 25 years, starting 2000. The search for related papers was conducted on 20 March 2026. The publication and geographical trends indicate rising literature in this field from last decade, particularly from China. The Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) method has been used to select the literature, thereby reducing the risk of bias. R studio was used for analysis and presentation.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Nutritional Quality Assessment of Different Foods Using the Nutrient Rich Food (NRF) Index: An Empirical Analysis
Full author name	Niyansh Mittal
School name	Modern School
School address	Barakhamba Road, New Delhi-110001, India
Email id	mniyansh@gmail.com
Abstract	Background/Objective Nutrient profiling is proving to be a useful strategy for assessing food quality and promoting healthier food choices. This study analyses the nutritional quality of food products by applying the Nutrient Rich Food (NRF) Index, a validated method which considers the nutrients that need to be restricted and the ones which are beneficial. Methods The nutritional composition data such as macronutrients, dietary fiber, vitamins and minerals, saturated fat, added sugar and sodium were obtained from the product labels and published databases. The NRF Index was computed for each product and Pearson correlation and regression analyses were performed to examine relationships between the NRF Index and sugar and sodium. Results Dietary fiber, vitamins and minerals were associated with higher NRF scores, indicating a favorable nutrient-density profile of foods. Sugar content had a strong negative correlation with NRF scores, and sodium content had a strong positive linear correlation with NRF scores. There was no evidence of omitted variable bias and no heteroskedasticity from regression diagnostics. Conclusions The NRF Index is a science-based, practical tool for measuring food quality. The results in this study have highlighted the potential for the application of nutrient profiling for food product development and nutrition public health programs and its relevance to the resolution of nutrient challenges arising from modern life.
Keyword	Nutrient Rich Food Index (NRF), Nutrient Density, Nutrient Profiling, Food Quality Assessment, Dietary Fibre, Functional Foods, Public Health Nutrition

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Inclusive Education in Gujarat: A Study of Governance and Institutional Practices
Full author name	Zeus Lalani
School name	Navrachana International School
School address	Vadodara
Email id	zeuslalani7861@gmail.com
Abstract	In many parts of the world, inclusive infrastructural and techniques are deployed to address the issues of exclusion of students with disabilities in education. Its adoption in the Indian state systems of education, however, is progressively influenced by governmental administration, policy creation, and schools' individual needs. This research paper examines these inclusionary and access focused practice as the location influenced by state power, policy and execution. The area of study is the domain of public education in the state of Gujarat in India. The design of this study is qualitative-dominant mixed methods. It examines the conceptualization, design and regulation of inclusion focused projects for physically disabled learners from a government perspective, based on the review of policy frameworks and the research methods of surveys and interviews. The paper discusses the role of eligibility requirements, distribution of funds, and administrative processes in determining access to assistive devices and digital learning instruments. It examines the possibility of discrimination based on class, gender and geographical location, including the voices of those managing the administrative aspects of the state-led technological and policy interventions. These results suggest that while inclusive policies have much potential in enhancing participation in education, inclusion is still dependent on a range of intersecting socio-economic factors. Who is supported, the definition of inclusion in social identity terms of the beneficiary and the significance of certain disabilities in the policy system are all determined by the real-time implementation of government policies.
Keyword	inclusive education, disability, education policies, state interventions.

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	An Empirical Analysis of the Impact of Macroeconomic Variables on Maggi Sales in India's Fast Moving Consumer Goods Industry
Full author name	Abhiuday Maini
School name	The Shri Ram School
School address	Moulsari, V-37, Moulsari Avenue,122002, Gurugram, India
Email id	abhiudaymaini2012@gmail.com
Abstract	The Fast Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) industry has an important contribution to the Indian economy, and Maggi remains the market leader for instant noodles because of its brand recognition and customer loyalty. But with changing economic conditions, inflation, population growth and changes in consumer behaviour, there is uncertainty over what is driving sales performance. The primary aim of this study is to examine the effect of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), Consumer Price Index (CPI), Population and Year on the sales of Maggi over the years. Time Series secondary data had been used to test the macroeconomic variables affecting the sales of Maggi using the multiple regression model. The findings show that GDP has a strong positive relationship with the sales of Maggi. This highlighted an important relation between economic growth and consumer demand in the FMCG sector. The study also emphasizes the impact of macroeconomic factors on the FMCG industry in India with respect to consumer buying and sales. The results of this study can help businesses, marketers and policy makers understand the impact of economic downturns on markets for consumer goods and help them to design better business and economic policies. The overall contribution of the research is that it provides empirical evidence about the correlation between the economic indicators and the sales of Maggi in India, thus adding to the existing literature on FMCG sales performance and the analysis of macroeconomic indicators.
Keyword	Maggi Sales, Gross Domestic Product (GDP), Consumer Price Index (CPI), FMCG Industry, Consumer Behaviour.

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Judging Cake by Its Cover: Sighted and Blind Evaluations of Gluten-Free Versus Conventional Cake
Full author name	Suvenaa Tayal
School name	--
School address	--
Email id	suvenaatayal@gmail.com
Abstract	There are preconceived notions about the sensory properties of gluten-free products that lead to their perceived inferiority to conventional products. But few studies have investigated how these perceptions are affected by visual cues and prior knowledge, rather than the sensory characteristics of the products themselves. The present study is designed to examine the effects of visual cues and preconceived notions on consumers' perceptions and preferences towards gluten-free and conventional cakes. The study is based on the multisensory perception of food and uses a within-subjects experimental design with 39 participants from one organisation. Descriptive statistics, Chi-square test and McNemar's test are used for analysing quantitative data, and thematic analysis for analysing qualitative responses. The results show that there were statistically significant differences between the participants' scores for texture and density, in favour of the gluten-free cake in the blind tasting. Further evidence of the influence of visual cues on initial evaluations of products is the large difference between sighted preferences and blind texture judgements. Qualitative results also indicate that participants' perceptions are mostly influenced by unfamiliarity and preconceived notions. The results confirm the potential role of multisensory perception in consumer assessments and emphasise the need to increase consumer awareness in addition to the development of gluten-free products with better sensory properties.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Factors affecting Consumer Food Price Inflation in India
Full author name	SHAMBHAVI MITTAL
School name	City Montessori School
School address	Cambridge Section, Gomti Nagar, Lucknow (226010)
Email id	shambhavimittal14@gmail.com
Abstract	This study examines the determinants of food price movements in India with the aim of assessing the influence of exchange rates, crude oil prices, monetary policy, and fertilizer prices on the Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI). The research focuses on the relationship between CFPI and five key macroeconomic and input-cost variable which are USD/INR exchange rate, EUR/INR exchange rate, Brent crude oil prices, the repo rate, and the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) of fertilizers and nitrogen compounds within the Indian economic context. The study adopts a quantitative research methodology using secondary annual data compiled from official Government of India for the period 2000–2025. The data was analyzed using multiple linear regression in STATA to evaluate the relationship between food prices and the selected explanatory variables. The analysis reveals that fertilizer prices have a statistically significant positive relationship with CFPI, indicating the importance of agricultural input costs in explaining food price movements. The EUR/INR exchange rate demonstrates a marginally significant relationship at the 10% level, while Brent crude oil prices, the USD/INR exchange rate, and the repo rate do not exhibit statistically significant effects within the estimated model. The regression model demonstrates a high explanatory power, with an R-squared value of 0.9788. These findings highlight the importance of fertilizer and agricultural input costs in understanding food price dynamics in India and suggest that policies aimed at managing input-cost pressures may contribute to greater food-price stability. The study contributes to the existing literature by examining multiple macroeconomic and production-cost factors within a unified empirical framework and provides insights that may be relevant to policymakers, economists, and researchers studying food-price dynamics in India.
Keyword	Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI), Fertilizer Prices, Food Price Inflation, Exchange Rates, Brent Crude Oil, Repo Rate

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	From Elasticity to Energy Mix: Modelling India's Path to Net-Zero
Full author name	Mehak Jindal
School name	Delhi Technological University
School address	--
Email id	mehakjindal_25phdhueco503@dtu.ac.in
Abstract	India's energy system must accommodate economic expansion while addressing emissions reduction and energy security. This study combines econometric estimation with long-term energy-system optimisation to examine these interactions. Using 1990-2023 data, a log-log regression framework quantifies the responsiveness of energy demand to economic output across major sectors. These elasticity estimates inform a MARKAL-based least-cost model exploring India's energy pathways through 2047. Results show an economy-wide energy-GDP elasticity of 0.62, indicating energy demand grows more slowly than GDP. Sectoral estimates reveal significant heterogeneity: transport shows a notably higher elasticity of 0.96, marking it as a priority area for demand-side intervention. Three scenarios- Business-as-Usual, NDC-Aligned, and Net-Zero- are modelled under differing demand and technology assumptions. By 2030, final energy requirements reach 37,962 PJ (Business-as-Usual), 35,221 PJ (NDC-Aligned), and 33,221 PJ (Net-Zero). By 2047, the Net-Zero pathway yields 41,513 PJ, roughly 19.6% below the Business-as-Usual level of 51,618 PJ, while reducing coal's share from 44% to 8%. Notably, decarbonisation and diversification yield divergent outcomes: the Net-Zero pathway records a Herfindahl-Hirschman Index of 0.228, higher than the NDC pathway's 0.179, reflecting greater supply concentration due to increased reliance on solar. These findings indicate that emissions reduction and portfolio diversification are distinct objectives requiring separate indicators, targets, and monitoring frameworks. This distinction allows policymakers to pursue decarbonisation without compromising energy security and supply resilience.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Corporate Governance Failure and Creative Accounting: A Case Study of the Satyam Computer Services Scandal
Full author name	Ria Jain
School name	Shikshantar Secondary School
School address	J block, South City-1, Haryana, Gurgoan 122001
Email id	riajain1602@gmail.com
Abstract	The Satyam Computer Services scandal is a landmark case of fraudulent corporate activity, which has demonstrated serious gaps in corporate governance, accountability, and financial reporting systems in India. The comparison of Enron, WorldCom and Satyam reveals that corporate accounting fraud is an increasing menace in terms of frequency and magnitude. As empirical evidence has revealed, the sheer level of increase in such frauds has undermined the quality of financial reporting, caused massive economic losses and undermined the confidence of investors in the utility and credibility of financial reporting. The rising trend of white-collar crimes requires tougher punishments, exemplary punitive actions, and sound administration of the law in accordance with accountable governance. This study presents an inquiry and analysis of the Satyam Computer Services creative accounting scandal, highlighting the critical role played by ethics and corporate governance, using data sourced from Scopus and following PRISMA guidelines, with no restrictions on publication year and based on predefined keywords along with clearly defined inclusion and exclusion criteria. The example of the fraud committed by the founders in 2009 is the illustration of the way the science of conduct may be deeply impacted by human greed, ambition, and desire to dominate power, wealth, fame, and recognition. Satyam fell into a tunnelling effect unlike Enron which experienced agency problems that lead to its downfall. The scandal highlights the importance of securities laws and corporate governance in the emerging market. In fact, the Satyam fraud has given the Indian government the impetus to increase the norms of corporate governance so as to ensure that similar frauds do not recur. As such, significant financial reporting frauds should be examined with the aim of learning and approaches to be taken to curb such events in the future.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	How Artificial Intelligence Has Transformed the Manufacturing Industry: A Mixed-Methods Investigation of Operational Effects in an Apparel Manufacturing Organization
Full author name	Aarav Chopra
School name	The Shri Ram School Aravali
School address	--
Email id	chopra.aarav27@gmail.com
Abstract	Background/Objective Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly changing the manufacturing industry, but few implementation studies have been published, particularly for apparel manufacturing organizations in developing economies. This study investigates the effects of AI implementation on operational efficiency, operations, workforce, supply chain, and organizational-level outcomes within an apparel manufacturing organization. The study investigates the timing of adoption, technologies used, measurable operational effects, challenges faced, and organizational-level changes caused by AI being used in various functions within the organization. Methods Employing thematic analysis according to Braun and Clarke1, text patterns were meaningfully and systematically explored within the data. The analysis was performed as: (1) Familiarization: Reading all responses thoroughly multiple times; (2) Open Coding: Identifying meaningful segments of text and coding them according to what was said; (3) Axial Coding: Grouping the codes and establishing relationships between them; (4) Theme Development: Finding overall themes that encompass shared patterns, causal conditions, and consequences. Themes were iteratively checked for accuracy and supported with appropriate respondent quotes. Results Four overall themes emerged from the literature review regarding AI in the manufacturing industry. The first pertained to the AI adoption timeline and the different departments that first adopted AI in their manufacturing plants. AI was first adopted between 2020 and 2022 by quality assurance and production departments. The second theme was the efficiency gains that were made possible through the adoption of AI in the manufacturing plants. The results of efficiency gains included a 25%-45% improvement in production cycle times, 99%+ accuracy in the detection of defective products, a 17%-24% decrease in material waste, and a 13-20% improvement in the effectiveness of manufacturing equipment. The third main theme included the hurdles that were encountered during the implementation of AI in these plants. The hurdles included difficulties in integrating AI with existing manufacturing data and control systems, issues in integrating with the existing manufacturing plants, resistance from the manufacturing workers during the change process, and the need to manage this change in manufacturers. The fourth and final theme included the changes to the workers and the organizations. The workers shifted from the performance of the manufacturing tasks to the oversight of these tasks. Additionally, all workers had to be retrained to perform these new tasks (between 50 and 80 hours each). Furthermore, the supply chain and the organization as a whole became data oriented in the implementation of AI in the manufacturing plants. Finally, the efficiency gains from AI in the manufacturing plants were associated with cost savings of 15-32% in manufacturing costs and 70-80% in supply chain costs. Conclusion AI in the manufacturing plants has had a significant and quantifiable impact upon those manufacturing operations. However, to fully realize these benefits, manufacturers must make an investment in transforming their organizations in a holistic manner. While AI may lead to the automation of manufacturing tasks, it also leads to the upskilling of the workforce and the changing of their organizational culture. Thus, rather than leading to the displacement of manufacturing workers, AI leads to the evolution of the workforce to tasks of higher values. Consequently, any organization that wishes to gain a competitive edge in the manufacturing sector must be prepared to make an investment in the transformation of their organization that relates to both the technical and human aspects of that transformation
Keyword	Artificial Intelligence; Manufacturing; Operational Efficiency; Digital Transformation; Supply Chain Management; Computer Vision; Machine Learning; Apparel Manufacturing; Industry 4.0; Workforce Adaptation

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Effect of Direct and Freezone Company Structures on Trade in the UAE during the Covid Pandemic
Full author name	Vihaan Suvarna
School name	Dubai International Academy
School address	Al Barsha
Email id	vihaanssuvarna@gmail.com
Abstract	The trade settings and wide-ranging shocks are key in the evaluation of economic resilience and longterm policy. This paper discusses the impact of COVID-19 on imports, exports and jobs in both direct (onshore) and free-zone company arrangements in the UAE. The purpose is to identify the response of these different trade environments to an unprecedented global shock and to see what structural weaknesses arose during and after the crisis. Interrupted Time Series Analysis had been used to analyze the data from 2011 to 2023 annually, understanding the way trade patterns have changed before and after the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. The results show the main economic indicators of the UAE in trade and exports which are total imports, direct imports, free zone imports, UAE non-oil exports, and UAE GDP. It was observed that there was an increased trend in total imports shortly after the pandemic began. This evidence indicated that economic policy after the pandemic needs to focus on stabilization of import levels and building long-term resilience of trade, rather than stimulating trade in the shorter term. These results highlight the importance of implementing strategic changes that will focus on economic diversification, strategic planning, and empowerment of the non-oil sector. The insights obtained can be of great value to policy makers, investors, and logistics practitioners who are determined to make the UAE economy more resilient.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Algorithmic Caste System: Gig Work, Informality and Caste Formations in Urban India
Full author name	Amaira Jain
School name	Modern School
School address	Barakhamba Road
Email id	amairajain2010@gmail.com
Abstract	This research project examines the intersection of caste, informality, and platform capitalism, asking how digital labour platforms reshape, conceal, and at times reinforce social inequality. According to the India Employment Report 2024, published by the Institute for Human Development and the International Labour Organisation, nearly ninety per cent of India's workforce remains informally employed, and this informality has never been caste-neutral. As platforms increasingly mediate everyday work, they risk reproducing rather than dismantling longstanding hierarchies, now through algorithmic management, consumer-driven ratings, and opaque systems of evaluation. Yet how these hierarchies are enacted at the point of interaction remains underexamined. This study therefore investigates the perceptions and everyday encounters of middle-class urban consumers with gig workers, tracing how such encounters reproduce deeper caste-class relations beneath the veneer of technological neutrality. Drawing on primary survey data, semi-structured interviews, and secondary literature, it develops a Social Distance Index, adapted from the Bogardus Social Distance Scale and calibrated to the conditions of the platform economy, to measure these relations empirically. The findings are striking: nearly two-thirds of respondents (64.7%) scored above the lowest band of social distance, with almost 40% falling into the highest band and even on the more guarded measure of active discrimination, one in five admitted bias-consistent behaviour despite strong social pressure to deny it. Social boundaries once drawn along caste and class lines persist, largely intact, within ostensibly neutral digital transactions. On this basis, the paper contends that India's existing legal framework is insufficient to address discrimination embedded within data-driven systems of work organisation. Bringing together labour law, political economy, science and technology studies, it proposes a discrimination-conscious regulatory framework built on algorithmic accountability, transparency, and stronger protections for platform workers. In doing so, the study contributes to the emerging scholarship on platform labour while offering a distinctly Indian account of how historical structures of inequality continue to shape the digital economy.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	What Drives Female Entrepreneurship? A Comparative Analysis of Developed and Developing Economies
Full author name	Naisha Kapoor
School name	The Shri Ram School
School address	Moulsari
Email id	naishakapoor1@gmail.com
Abstract	Female entrepreneurship is recognised as a key driver of inclusive growth and gender empowerment. This study investigates the macroeconomic determinants of female entrepreneurship across 20 developed and developing economies from 2000 to 2024, addressing a gap in the comparative quantitative literature. Feasible Generalised Least Squares (FGLS) is employed following the selection of fixed effects for developing economies and random effects for developed economies, with diagnostics confirming heteroskedasticity and first-order autocorrelation in both sub-samples. Health emerges as the strongest predictor in both groups, exerting a significant negative effect that is larger in developed economies (−0.443) than in developing economies (−0.284), reflecting the substitution of self-employment for formal work as health conditions improve. Female labour force participation reveals the most economically significant divergence: negative in developing economies (−0.063), indicating a substitution effect as expanding formal employment draws women away from necessity-driven self-employment, and positive in developed economies (+0.229), indicating a complementarity effect where formal employment serves as a springboard for entrepreneurship. Moreover, education is positively significant in developing economies (+0.026) but insignificant in developed economies, consistent with a ceiling effect in female enrolment. Finally, fertility imposes a significant negative penalty only in developed economies (−1.298), where work–family trade-offs are most acute, while domestic credit is insignificant in developing economies and significantly negative in developed economies (−0.015), suggesting aggregate credit flows toward incumbents rather than first-time women entrepreneurs. Hence, the study derives policy implications for governments and development agencies seeking to promote gender-equitable entrepreneurship.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Perceptions of Development under Viksit Bharat: A Thematic Analysis of Economic, Social, and Infrastructure Dimensions
Full author name	Rayan Kapoor
School name	The Doon School
School address	Dehradun
Email id	harshkap@gmail.com
Abstract	This paper examines citizens' perceptions of development under the Viksit Bharat vision using qualitative responses collected through a Google Form from 21 respondents. The analysis uses open coding and axial coding to identify five major themes: economic well-being, social development, infrastructure and urban living, governance and inclusion, and sustainability. The findings show that participants recognised progress in employment opportunities, public services, education, healthcare and infrastructure. However, they also highlighted persistent concerns regarding inequality, women's safety, traffic, public service gaps, transparency, pollution, and environmental degradation. Overall, respondents understood Viksit Bharat not only as economic growth, but as inclusive, sustainable, transparent and citizen-centred development.
Keyword	Viksit Bharat, Development, Thematic Analysis, Infrastructure, Governance, Sustainability, Inclusion

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Evaluating Overvalued Vs Undervalued Formula 1 Drivers
Full author name	Aryavir Gulati
School name	Institut Le Rosey Château du Rosey
School address	1180 Rolle, Switzerland
Email id	gulatiaryavir@gmail.com
Abstract	In Formula 1, on-track results are influenced substantially by car performance in addition to driver skill, and driver salaries exhibit considerable disparity, ranging from under $1 million to in excess of $60 million annually. This study examines whether driver salary is associated with on-track performance, using data from the complete 2025 season (24 races and 6 sprint races, N = 21 drivers). To isolate driver skill from car performance, on-track performance was operationalised as head-to-head win percentage against a same-team teammate, given that teammates compete using identical machinery. Data were analyzed using robust regression in Stata to account for the disproportionate leverage exerted by a small number of high-salary outliers on the model. Results indicated that salary was a statistically significant predictor of head-to-head performance (b = 1.09, p = .009), while age was not (p = .321). These findings suggest that a driver's salary is meaningfully associated with their on-track performance relative to their teammate, and that the sport's most pronounced cases of driver overvaluation and undervaluation are concentrated among high-salary outliers. Overall, this study demonstrates that driver salary is a significant predictor of on-track performance in Formula 1 once car quality is controlled for and the disproportionate influence of extreme salary outliers is accounted for, indicating that pay and performance are meaningfully linked in ways that conventional analysis can obscure. Future research should extend this analysis across multiple seasons using verified contract data to determine whether this relationship holds consistently over time.
Keyword	Formula 1, driver salary, performance evaluation, robust regression, sports economics

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Economic Sustainability of Singapore's Hawker Sector: The Role of Consumer Preferences, Cost Pressures, and Cultural Value
Full author name	Krishiv Sharma
School name	North London Collegiate School
School address	Singapore, 130 Depot Rd, Singapore 109708
Email id	reachks18@gmail.com
Abstract	Background/Objective: Hawker centres in Singapore function both as small businesses and as significant cultural spaces within a highly formalised economy. Despite their importance, hawkers face increasing operating costs, evolving consumer behaviour, labour constraints, and competition from food-delivery services. This study examines the economic sustainability of Singapore's hawker sector by analysing how commercial pressures, consumer preferences, and cultural value influence its long-term viability. Methods: Survey data were collected from 60 people, comprising 30 hawker stall operators and 30 consumers, at various hawker centers in Singapore. The survey responses were turned into composite indices for Hawker Economic Sustainability (HES), Cost Pressure (CP), Consumer Preference (CSP), and Cultural Value Perception (CVP). Descriptive statistics, Pearson correlation analysis, and Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression were applied to examine the relationships among these variables. The results showed that consumer preference had the most positive relationship with the economic sustainability of hawker centres, whereas cost pressure was negatively linked to business performance. Cultural value perception was positively connected to consumer support for hawker centres but showed a less strong direct relationship with economic sustainability. The overall conclusion is that hawker sustainability is the result of the interaction between commercial conditions and consumer behaviour rather than being determined solely by cultural significance. Conclusion: The study shows that it is necessary to strike a balance between economic competitiveness and the cultural and social roles of Singapore's hawker centers; thus, retaining affordability, meeting consumer demand, and staying culturally relevant while adapting to digitalization may be key to the sector's long-term sustainability.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Microenterprise as Complement or Substitute? Institutional Ecosystems and Refugee Women's Entrepreneurship in the United States
Full author name	Diya Nigam
School name	Lexington High School
School address	--
Email id	diyanigam6@gmail.com
Abstract	This study examines how state-level microenterprise policy environments impact the economic opportunities for refugee women in the United States and whether microentrepreneurship is a complement or substitute to formal employment. While integration policies emphasize wage employment, refugee women often remain out of formal labor markets due to various barriers. It channels many into necessity-driven microenterprises, which are hardly considered in official integration metrics. To address this gap, the study develops a Microenterprise Ecosystem Index (MEI) across all 50 US states and the District of Columbia, providing a comparative framework of institutional opportunity structures for refugee women. The index captures cross-state variation in cottage food regulation, microloan access, and the presence of a federal refugee microenterprise program. The analysis uses a combination of institutional benchmarking with qualitative case evidence to identify mechanisms linking policy environments and entrepreneurial outcomes. The findings depict significant variation in the interstate ecosystem quality, with the presence of federal microenterprise programs emerging as the strongest driver of differences. Coordinated ecosystems tend to create conditions that support more viable forms of entrepreneurship, while fragmented ecosystems push many activities into lower-return informal work. The evidence from case studies also suggests that microenterprises often complement formal employment through income generation, skill development, credit access, and building gradual pathways towards either formal business growth or wage employment. The study proposes an ecosystem-based institutional framework for refugee entrepreneurship and highlights how microenterprises remain an under-measured dimension of integration that collaborates with formal labor markets. Overall, the findings suggest that current metrics of integration understate the economic contributions of refugee women and disregard key pathways of economic incorporation.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Preservation or Commercialisation: Resident Experiences of Heritage in Ahmedabad's Walled City
Full author name	Shiv Mandlik
School name	Adani International School
School address	--
Email id	shivnm7@gmail.com
Abstract	The focus of this paper is on how the UNESCO World Heritage designation impacts the lives of pol residents, which are traditional gated residential areas within Ahmedabad's Walled City area that was designated as part of a UNESCO World Heritage site in July 2017. While there is a general consensus among those responsible for implementing conservation policy that being listed as a world heritage site will be a positive development for all stakeholders involved, little consideration has been given to the 'lived' friction experienced by the people who live in these homes. A qualitative research methodology utilising semi-structured interviews conducted with fifteen long-term owners/artisans/shopkeepers/younger-generation residents/community/panch leaders residing in ten pols. QDA Miner Lite was used to conduct reflexive thematic analysis, which identified four axial categories: commercialisation/market pressure; bureaucratic/regulatory friction; psycho-spatial displacement/domestic alienation; and heritage identity, attachment, and community loss. Among these prevalent pressures (i.e., bureaucratic friction is the extended time periods for municipal approvals and the requirement for expensive restoration) was the bureaucratic friction, which drove displacement: long-time residents who have assets but do not have access to capital, cannot lawfully maintain their properties and thus are funnelled toward developers and conversion to commercial space. Concurrently, the tourist gaze recodes private spaces such as the otla and chowk into public spectacles creating "a living museum" alienation, particularly evident among women and the elderly. These results suggest that preservation as it is now administered will manufacture the very commercialisation it claims to avoid, and therefore that humane, participative governance is needed so that heritage and habitation can exist together.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Impact of Automation on Workers in Informal Industrial Work in North India
Full author name	Daksh Agarwal
School name	Neerja Modi School
School address	Jaipur
Email id	dakshagarwal.w@gmail.com
Abstract	Automation is transforming the manufacturing sector across the world. However the research on its effects on workers is insufficient, particularly in the developing economies.In this regard, this study focuses on automation awareness, perceptions of job insecurity, skills transformation, and well-being of workers amongst 67 shop floor workers working at an automobile parts manufacturing firm in Jaipur, India. The survey was conducted in Hindi language with a physical questionnaire amongst the workers in April 2026 focusing on twelve dimensions of automation such as awareness about automation, benefits and limitations, training needs, willingness to invest in skills development, and preferred adaptation methods in case of job displacement. This study found workers aware of automation but confused about what it entails with most of the respondents having a narrow view of automation as machines replacing tasks rather than as digital transformation of industrial processes. Moreover, the workers were concerned about productivity aspects of automation on one hand and fear of losing their jobs, income disparity, and inability to afford the training costs on the other. There was not a single worker who thought that their skills would be adequate enough for an automated environment. Taking into account recent research on automation and its impact on worker well-being (Nazareno & Schiff, 2021; Li et al., 2026), the analysis shows that the above perceptions have practical implications for the well-being of workers, and, therefore, the policies aimed at tackling the consequences of automation should pay due attention to these problems. The results of this paper highlights the importance of targeted training programs, well-funded retraining opportunities so that they could be affordable for the masses and a stronger social safety net protection in order to account for the human side of industrial automation. In accordance with Kasy and Sautmann (2022), the optimal approach to solving problems related to automation should be context-specific, and the current research provides a solid basis for that.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Effect of Budget Airlines in the Indian Aviation Sector
Full author name	Aaryan Bakshi
School name	Merryland International School
School address	6 Ramlat Al 'Iqaylah Street, Abu Dhabi, Abu Dhabi Emirate
Email id	aaryanbakshi09@gmail.com
Abstract	This study examines how low-cost carriers (LCCs) have shaped India's domestic aviation market. Using secondary market-share, fare, passenger, operational and regulatory data, the study evaluates five hypotheses concerning competition, consumer surplus, operational efficiency, safety and average prices. The analysis covers the Indian domestic market primarily from 2000 to 2024, while selected 2025 observations are used to examine the IndiGo scheduling crisis and recent market conditions. The findings indicate that LCC entry is associated with stronger competition, wider connectivity and lower average fares. Evidence also supports improvements in operational efficiency, particularly through fleet standardization, aircraft utilization and shorter turnaround times. The safety hypothesis is not supported: the available evidence does not indicate that LCC expansion has lowered the overall safety standard, although the 2025 IndiGo disruption demonstrates how regulatory non-compliance and highly optimized scheduling can create operational vulnerability. Average-price comparisons further show a substantial gap between LCC and full-service fares. The study concludes that the LCC model has contributed materially to the democratization and structural transformation of Indian domestic aviation, while highlighting the need for strong regulatory oversight and transparent pricing. low-cost carriers; Indian aviation; competition; airfare; safety; consumer surplus
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	COVID-19 as a Structural Break in Indian Stock Market Volatility: An ARIMAX–Interrupted Time Series Analysis of the NIFTY 50 (2013–2024)
Full author name	Kian Jindal
School name	Heritage International Xperiential School
School address	--
Email id	kian.jindal2010@gmail.com
Abstract	The present study examines the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on the volatility dynamics of the Indian equity market, using the NIFTY 50 index as a proxy. An Interrupted Time Series Analysis (ITSA) embedded within an ARIMAX framework is employed to analyze daily data from 2013 to 2024, with the nationwide lockdown beginning on 24 March 2020 treated as an exogenous structural break. The model captures both the immediate level shift in volatility following the onset of the pandemic and the long-run change in its trend, while accounting for serial correlation and volatility clustering. The empirical results indicate a statistically significant surge in market volatility immediately after the lockdown, reflecting heightened uncertainty, liquidity pressures, and investor overreaction. Furthermore, the interaction between time and the post-COVID dummy variable reveals a significant change in the slope of volatility, suggesting a transition to a new volatility regime characterized by a higher baseline risk but gradual normalization over time. Counterfactual analysis further shows that, in the absence of the pandemic, volatility would have followed a much smoother and less steep trajectory. Overall, the findings provide strong evidence that COVID-19 constituted a structural break in the Indian equity market, altering both the level and the long-term dynamics of volatility. This study contributes to the existing literature by offering long-horizon empirical evidence from an emerging market and by demonstrating the effectiveness of quasi-experimental time-series methods in assessing the persistent financial impacts of systemic shocks.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Impact of Instagram Followers, Age, Brand Endorsements, and Matches Played on Professional Football Players' Market Value
Full author name	Ravo Shingadia
School name	NIST International School
School address	36 Sukhumvit 15, Klongtoey-nua Watthana, Bangkok 10110, Thailand
Email id	ravoshingadia@gmail.com
Abstract	Background/Objective In today's day and age, professional footballers are no longer just meant to be valued for their performance on the field but also for their off the field attributes such as their age, experience, social media presence, and marketability. Social media, specifically Instagram, has turned into a valuable asset to develop a player's profile and brand; age and number of matches played indicates experience, development, potential and longevity of a player's career. However, how many Instagram followers, age, number of brand endorsement industries and number of matches played are associated with a professional football player's market value are still not known. This study analyzes if any relationship exists between these variables and market value, as well as the magnitude of the relationship. Methods A multiple linear regression model was estimated in STATA MP 18 for this study. The data informed here includes player data (name, age, nationalities, market value). Data from the dataset was complemented with the number of Instagram followers, number of brand-endorsement industries, and number of matches played of the players. The dependent variable was the market value, and the independent variables were the number of countries the player is from, the number of Instagram followers, number of brand-endorsement industries, number of matches played and age of the player. Prior to running the regression, scatter plots were created for each predictor against the market value to look for linearity. Results The regression model was statistically significant, $F(5, 475) = 311.15$, $p < .001$, and explained approximately 76.6% of the variance in market value ($R^2 = .7661$, Adjusted $R^2 = .7636$). Market value was positively predicted by number of matches played ($\beta = 0.822$, $p < .001$), number of Instagram followers ($\beta = 0.0006$, $p < .001$), and the presence of a developing country, where a player was from ($\beta = 10.01$, $p < .001$). The number of brand-endorsement industries approached significance ($\beta = 18.06$, $p = .054$) and age was not a significant predictor ($\beta = -0.29$, $p = .123$). These trends were further confirmed as market value was strongly correlated with Instagram followers ($r = .769$, $p < .001$) and matches played ($r = .749$, $p < .001$), and moderately correlated with brand industries ($r = .565$, $p < .001$). Multicollinearity was not a serious issue (mean VIF = 2.59), but heteroskedasticity ($\chi^2(1) = 212.91$, $p < .001$) and possibly model misspecification (Ramsey RESET $F(3, 472) = 25.19$, $p < .001$) were identified from the diagnostic tests. Conclusions The findings indicate that a player's market valuation is well-supported by experience in playing matches and commercial and social media presence as evidenced by the number of his Instagram followers and the number of brands he is associated with, but not by his age alone. This means that in today's game visibility and marketability can be more important than experience in influencing player-value by either clubs or the market. The model is explanatory, but with possible heteroskedasticity and omitted variable bias, it would benefit from being improved before the results are considered as definitive, for example by transforming variables or introducing on-pitch performance variables.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Assessing Public Awareness and Perceived Effectiveness of Sustainability Initiatives in Indian Railways
Full author name	Vihana Gaidhani
School name	Dubai International Academy Emirates Hills
School address	Dubai, United Arab Emirates, 00000
Email id	vihanasg@gmail.com
Abstract	Indian Railways (IR) has committed to achieving net-zero carbon emissions by 2030 through large-scale electrification, renewable energy integration, and allied environmental programs. Yet the extent to which passengers are aware of and perceive value in these initiatives remains empirically underexplored. This study addresses that gap through a structured survey of 87 respondents spanning diverse age, gender, and educational demographics. Findings reveal that infrastructure-visible initiatives, notably track electrification, command the highest public awareness, while high-impact but low-visibility programs such as Dedicated Freight Corridors attract awareness rates as low as 6–13%. Significant demographic disparities were identified: respondents aged 23–27 exhibited the lowest awareness across all initiative categories, and awareness patterns were shaped by gender-linked thematic preferences. These results carry direct implications for IR's public communication and engagement strategy.
Keyword	Indian Railways, sustainability, public awareness, perceived effectiveness, net-zero, electrification, demographic analysis

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	The Economics and Appeal of Dance Workshops: Predicting Interest in Diverse Dance Workshops
Full author name	Avni Bansal
School name	Dubai International Academy Emirates Hills
School address	First Al Khail St - Al Thanyah Fourth - Emirates Hills - Dubai - United Arab Emirates
Email id	avni13123@gmail.com
Abstract	Dance workshops are increasing in popularity because of its anti-stress and socializing factors. This paper examines the ways in which the dance workshops are affected by the number of people interested, price, dance type, duration, gender of organizer, age group, and couple or non-couple which is based on primary data of 34 workshops on the app BookMyShow, India. Quantitative research design was adopted and an XGBoost predictive model was applied to assess the importance of the variables and estimate the levels of interest. Analysis of the data involved encoding of the categorical variables, standardization of the numerical variables and dividing the dataset into training and testing subsets. Findings suggest that there is a significant interest difference between workshops, with popular types of dances like Bollywood and Salsa being involved more, and workshops that are both niche and more expensive experiencing lower attendance. The model showed a high predictive accuracy. There was a close correspondence between actual and predicted values. The analysis of factor importance identified the most significant predictors of interest to be dance style and price, as compared to duration, gender of organizer, and age group which had a relatively less significant impact. The results indicate the significance of the design matching the preferences of the participants and imply that the affordability and familiarity with the genre are the key factors influencing demand for the dance workshops.
Keyword	Dance workshop, Price, Type of Dance, Duration, Gender of Organizer, Age Group, Couple or Non Couple, Number of People Interested

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Sport Sponsorship, Branding and Marketing: A Bibliometric Analysis Using VOSviewer
Full author name	Suryavir Bhandari
School name	The Shri Ram School Maulsari
School address	V-37, Moulsari Ave, DLF Phase 3, Sector 24, Gurugram, Haryana 122010
Email id	suryavirbhandari@gmail.com
Abstract	This review presents a bibliometric map of the sport sponsorship, branding and marketing literature indexed in Scopus between 2000 and 2026. A systematic search restricted to journal articles in the business, social science, economics and humanities subject areas returned 211 documents, authored by 506 researchers across 140 journals and accumulating 3,667 citations at the point of extraction. Five VOSviewer analyses, all using full counting, were used to map this corpus: co-authorship among authors, organisations and countries; co-occurrence of all keywords; and bibliographic coupling among documents. The co-authorship analyses revealed a fragmented field organised around small author teams and largely single-institution contributions, with the United States, United Kingdom and Australia dominating both output and citations. The keyword co-occurrence map showed a stable core vocabulary of sponsorship, sport, marketing and branding, flanked by a commercial and communicative cluster centred on advertising and social media and by a methodological and health-related cluster arising from the tobacco, alcohol and gambling literature indexed in biomedical journals. Bibliographic coupling confirmed this fragmentation at the level of citations: the most cited works, spanning influencer celebrification, celebrity endorsement, mega-event legacy and gambling convergence, share almost no common reference base with one another. Nearly half of the corpus has appeared since 2020, reflecting rapid expansion into esports, influencer marketing and athlete name, image and likeness rights. The findings indicate that sponsorship value depends on brand-property congruence and sustained relational alignment rather than exposure alone, and that regulated categories continue to use sport to reach audiences beyond the reach of direct advertising. The review concludes that the field would benefit from greater cross-national, longitudinal and theoretically integrative research.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Exploring the Challenges and Opportunities for Marginalised Artisans: A Study on Sales, Barriers, and Consumer Perceptions
Full author name	Mehr Singh Takkar
School name	Neerja Modi World School
School address	--
Email id	mehrsinghtakkar@gmail.com
Abstract	India's 6.8 million artisans represent a significant economic and cultural workforce; however, despite their substantial contribution to the national economy, they continue to face multiple challenges and persistent marginalisation. This study examined consumer perceptions of handmade products by marginalised artisans and identified the barriers they face. This study employed a quantitative, survey-based approach, comprising two questionnaires: one for consumers and another for artisans. A total of 90 consumer responses and 25 artisan responses were collected and analysed using graphical representation and hypothesis testing. Specifically, Levene's test and t-test were used to analyse willingness to buy and pay for these products between males and females. The results indicated that pottery and ceramic products were the most commonly purchased artisan items among consumers. Most respondents learned about these products through local markets and exhibitions, underscoring the importance of traditional sales channels. Additionally, the primary reason for purchasing artisan goods was their unique handmade design and appreciation of traditional craftsmanship. Moreover, the findings revealed a significant gender difference, with females exhibiting greater willingness to purchase and pay for artisanal products. Finally, from the artisans' perspective, most rely on offline selling platforms such as craft fairs and local markets, with pricing often based on customers' willingness to pay rather than production costs. Although many artisans reported internet access, the use of digital platforms remains limited due to lower digital literacy. Overall, these findings highlight that despite growing consumer interest in handmade products, many artisans remain disadvantaged due to persistent barriers.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	From Informal Employment to Platform Work: Evidence on the Evolution of India's Gig Economy
Full author name	Roshni Gupta
School name	Mallya Aditi International School
School address	--
Email id	roshninafl08@gmail.com
Abstract	India's unorganised sector, including the gig economy, is characterised by short-term, flexible work for 83% of its workforce. This study employed a mixed-methods approach, utilising India's E-Shram database to identify trends in India's unorganised sector (2021-2025), and conducting a thematic analysis using interviews with gig workers, to investigate the opportunities and challenges in platform-based work. The heatmaps revealed that central-eastern India had the highest density of informal workers, attributable to the region's large scheduled caste population, low average income and its location in the fertile Indo-Gangetic Plains. Trend analysis of employment patterns indicated that COVID-19 catalysed the initial boom in 2021-2022, whereas market saturation and reduced incentives drove the subsequent decline in new registrations in 2023. A skewed 7:3 ratio of female to male informal workers was illustrated, which researchers credit to India's patriarchal society, favouring the formal employment of men and pushing women toward casual employment. In the gig economy, thematic analysis of the interviews revealed that, while valuable flexibility, in-depth training, and immediate income opportunities were available, the accompanying income volatility, opaque algorithmic control, and lack of social protections made gig workers vulnerable. Sixteen-hour working days with constant time-pressures created strain among workers, though accessible grievance redressal mechanisms were present. Hence, to ensure sustainable growth in India's gig economy, algorithmic improvements and transparency, clear legal definition of gig work, and government-driven schemes to provide employment benefits in this sector are essential.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	Modelling Healthcare Output in India: An Empirical Study of Production Factors
Full author name	Aarnav Das Vaidya
School name	North London Collegiate School
School address	Dubai
Email id	aarnavdasvaidya@gmail.com
Abstract	The Healthcare sector is considered one of the crucial components to drive the productivity of an economy. This research paper aimed to analyse trends and the relation between the factors of production and overall value added in the Indian healthcare sector. Using the time-series data from the Indian KLEMS database, a trend and regression analysis was conducted between 2001 and 2023. Based on the Cobb-Douglas production function, the study identified which of the factors significantly affected the total gross output of the Indian healthcare sector. The findings revealed that capital, material and service inputs positively affected the gross output of the healthcare sector. Capital was the input variable with the largest positive relationship with gross input as a 1% increase in capital input led to a 0.57% increase in gross output. Interestingly, for every 1% increase in labour, there was a 0.85% decrease in gross output. Finally, Energy input was the only input that did not have any significant impact on the overall value added. Hence, there are many ways to increase the value added in the Indian healthcare sector, such as increasing the significant factors of production or implementing policies changing the labour and energy landscape within the sector. One such policy could be improving working and living conditions in rural areas so that healthcare workers can be reallocated from urban to rural areas to reduce diminishing labour productivity. Therefore, resources should be efficiently distributed to improve the output in the Indian Healthcare system.
Keyword	--

INDIVIDUAL ABSTRACTS

Paper title	From Ambition to Action: Why International Climate Agreements Failed to Address the Systems Driving Climate Change & the Provisions They Should Have Included
Full author name	Meher Singhi
School name	Nord Anglia International School Dubai
School address	Al Barsha 3, Dubai, UAE
Email id	mehersinghi.2010@gmail.com
Abstract	Despite decades of scientific evidence and international recognition of climate change as a global challenge, efforts to limit warming to 1.5°C have continued to fall short. This essay examines why major environmental agreements, including the Stockholm Declaration, Rio Declaration and Paris Agreement, have struggled to produce meaningful collective action. It argues that their central weakness was an overreliance on voluntary national commitments and emissions targets, without sufficiently addressing the economic, technological and institutional systems that sustain fossil fuel dependence. Through a policy analysis of existing international frameworks, this essay identifies four provisions that could have strengthened climate governance: sustainable urban development, international carbon pricing, binding compliance mechanisms and the protection of natural carbon sinks. The essay finds that effective climate action requires more than ambitious targets; it requires policies that reshape incentives, reduce structural dependence on high-carbon systems and create accountability for unmet commitments. By shifting the focus from reducing emissions after they are produced to transforming the structures that generate them, this essay highlights the importance of implementation mechanisms in international environmental governance. The findings suggest that the challenge facing climate agreements is not recognition of the problem, but the creation of institutions capable of turning collective ambition into measurable action.
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